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Higher ed reeling from conservative crackdown

Cuts, threats shock top schools into retrenchment

By Hilary Burns, Mike Damiano, and Diti Kohli
GLOBE STAFF

Just eight weeks into his term, Donald Trump has plunged the nation's top research universities into a period of austerity.

More than a dozen schools, including Harvard, MIT, Brown, and the University of Pennsylvania, have frozen hiring. Johns Hopkins University will lay off more than 2,000 workers. Boston University and Yale have directed administrators to slow spending. The University of Massachusetts' medical school rescinded dozens of admissions offers to PhD candidates and said layoffs are "going to be necessary."

Schools cited the same reason for these sweeping cuts: uncertainty about their financial futures driven by President Trump's threats and early moves to slash billions of dollars of federal funding, much of it tied to scientific research. Already, COLLEGES, Page A2

Slumping biotechs resigned to another year without cheer



The biotech index fund XBI is down nearly

5% since the start of the year. The biotech cluster based in Cambridge and Boston, the nation's largest, grapples with a record **16.1 million** square feet of unleased lab space.

By Robert Weisman
GLOBE STAFF

This was supposed to be the year of biotech's comeback.

At least that was the hope of many in the sector who started 2025 pointing to scientific advances and falling interest rates. Some foresaw a pickup in buyouts and initial public offerings, rewarding investors in the highly risky and cyclical business of bringing drugs to market.

But three months into the new year, the mood has soured and the outlook has clouded as a cyclone of threats and unknowns gathers speed. Despite some notable successes, including US approval in January of a nonopioid painkiller by Boston biotech Vertex, there are few signs the industry — responsible for more than 115,000 Massachusetts jobs — is pulling out of its four-year slump.

The biotech index fund XBI is down nearly 5 percent since the start of the year. The biotech cluster based in Cambridge and Boston, the nation's largest, BIOTECH, Page A9

A change for wetter

Sunday: Windy, rain late. High 61-66, low 53-58.

Monday: Lots of rain. High 57-62, low 35-40.

Complete report, **A24**.
Obituaries, **A22**.

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Seeing green — lots of it. Tips on traveling to the Emerald Isle of Ireland, with a proposed itinerary for a 10-day trip, **Travel, N11**.

The United States began large-scale military strikes against Iranian-backed rebels in Yemen, President Trump said, in a warning to Tehran. **A6**.

Spotlight.



Part 1

Welcome to Snitch City

BY DUGAN ARNETT AND ANDREW RYAN | GLOBE STAFF

ILLUSTRATION BY J.D. PAULSEN FOR THE GLOBE

New Bedford epitomizes the misuse of confidential informants, where police exploit an underworld with little oversight or accountability

NEW BEDFORD — During daylight hours, the docks of this city's historic port are a hive of activity — dive-bombing gulls, rumbling diesel trucks, and the playful banter of fishermen.

When night falls, the fishermen retreat to crowded triple-deckers or waterfront hotels and silence takes over, the only sounds coming from hulking boats that sway gently in Buzzards Bay.

Among them, on an early summer night in 2018, was the Little Tootie, a rust-scabbed scalloper based out of Newport News, Va., set to depart the next morning on a 10-day fishing trip down the Atlantic Coast.

Below deck, a handful of fishermen prepared for their journey. Some lay down to sleep.

Shortly before 9:30, they heard pounding on the wheelhouse door.

The stranger was dressed in black. His eyes were bloodshot. He had a pistol on his hip.

He pushed his way into the cabin, barged into the bunk of a sleeping fisherman, and dug furiously through the man's pockets.

Where are the drugs?

Jolted from sleep, the fisherman pushed and struggled to fight the intruder off.

An informant told me you're bringing drugs on the boat! the intruder shouted.

Amid the melee, a crew member dialed 911.

The call that came in to the New Bedford Police Department's dispatch center, a mile or two away, was short on details. A man had forced his way aboard. He was claiming to be a cop.

Even with this scant description, one name crept into the minds of the dispatchers.

Jorge.

SNITCH CITY, Page A12



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